

26th Annual Carolina Cup

October 2–4, 2026 • Columbia & Irmo, South Carolina

Welcome to our Carolina Cup guide. We put this together so everything about the weekend — travel, lodging, the venue, and what we're still waiting on from the tournament — lives in one place instead of scattered across emails and the group chat. As the tournament releases more information, we'll send updated versions of this same guide.

At a Glance

The one-minute version. If you read nothing else, read this.

Where	Ballentine Park Complex 1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063
When	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min from Savannah
Hotel	Hampton Inn Columbia I-26/Harbison Blvd — \$284/night 7.0 mi / ~13 min to the venue
Do today	Book the hotel — the Irmo area is already 80% sold out for these dates
Waiting on	Accepted teams (Sep 14) • Brackets (Sep 16) • Schedules (Sep 24)

1. Tournament Quick Start

Everything a busy parent needs, in under a minute.

Event	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Host	South Carolina United FC (SCUFC)
Team	Savannah United 17/18B Travel
Dates	Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026
Venue	Ballentine Park Complex 1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Age Group	U9 • 7v7 format
Format	Group play → knockout rounds
Entry Fee	\$725 per team for U8–U10 (7v7)
Check-in	Online check-in only. There is no on-site check-in.
Stay-to-Play	Not published — see Section 6
Drive	~169 miles • ~3h 15min via US-17 N → I-95 N → I-26 W
Parking	Free on-site at SCUFC complexes

2. Parent Action Items

DO THIS NOW

☐ Book your hotel

The Irmo area is already 80% booked for October 2–4. Rates we verified on September 13 ranged from \$100 to \$399 per night. See Section 6 for our picks and exact pricing.

COMING SOON — SEPTEMBER 14

☐ Watch for the accepted team list, then complete online check-in

The tournament posts accepted teams on September 14. Online check-in opens after that and **every team must complete it**. There is no on-site check-in at this event.

COMING SOON — SEPTEMBER 16 & 24

☐ Check the bracket, then the game schedule

Brackets post September 16 and the full schedule posts September 24. Once we have game times we'll send the updated guide with calculated departure times for each family.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Pack using the checklist

Section 12 has the full list. Early October in the Midlands swings from about 63°F in the morning to around 80°F in the afternoon — bring layers as well as heat gear.

BEFORE LEAVING HOME

☐ Review the tournament rules

SCUFC has not published the 2026 rules document yet. Section 13 explains what we know and what we're still waiting on.

3. What We Know & What We're Waiting For

Confirmed

Official Tournament Information: 26th Annual Carolina Cup, October 2–4, 2026, hosted by South Carolina United FC in the Columbia/Irmo area of South Carolina.

Official Tournament Information: Open to boys and girls teams, U8 through U19, at Recreational, Intermediate, and Advanced levels. U8–U10 play 7v7.

Official Tournament Information: All teams must complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in.

Official Tournament Information: Tournament director is Tripp Miller (tripp@scufc.com). SCUFC phone: 877-457-2832.

Confirmed Team Information: Savannah United 17/18B is scheduled to attend.

Pending Confirmation

Pending Confirmation: Accepted team list — posted September 14, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Bracket placement for our age group — posted September 16, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Game schedule and field assignments — posted September 24, 2026.

Pending Confirmation: Which of SCUFC's five complexes our team will play at, and the specific field within it.

Pending Confirmation: Whether a stay-to-play housing requirement applies to this event. No policy has been published.

Pending Confirmation: The 2026 tournament rules document, including game length, mercy rule, and tiebreakers.

Pending Confirmation: Coach instructions on arrival times, uniform, and team-specific details.

4. Tournament Overview

The Carolina Cup is run by South Carolina United FC and is now in its 26th year. It draws teams from across the Southeast to five complexes across the Columbia and Irmo area, and it has been one of the region's larger youth soccer weekends for a long time. Our U9 team will play 7v7.

Official Tournament Page (SincSports):
soccer.sincsports.com — [Carolina Cup](#)

Host Club:
southcarolinaunitedfc.com

Official Rules Document:
Not yet published for 2026

5. Travel & Arrival Planning

Drive from Savannah

Route: US-17 North → I-95 North (about 80 miles) → I-26 West (about 67 miles) → US-76 into Irmo.

Total: ~169 miles. Routing verified September 13, 2026.

Scenario	Time	Notes
Free-flow driving	~3h 15min	Routing engine, no stops
With a fuel and rest stop	~3h 35min	Add ~20 min
Friday evening traffic	~4h 00min	Add ~45 min

Why the first number is the real one: the free-flow figure of ~3h 15min is the routing calculation for the most direct route with no stops. The 3h 35min and 4h 00min figures are our own additions for a rest stop and for Friday evening traffic — they are planning buffers, not separate route measurements.

Player Report Time

Pending Confirmation. Game times are released September 24. Once we have them, we'll calculate each family's departure time so players arrive at the field **45 minutes before kickoff** for check-in, warm-up, and coach instructions. That gives parents a single departure time rather than a kickoff time to do math on.

Parent Manager Recommendation: An overnight stay avoids a pre-dawn Saturday drive. Two nights (Friday October 2 and Saturday October 3) is the pattern most traveling families use for this event.

6. Lodging

Housing requirement: SCUFC has not published a stay-to-play policy for the Carolina Cup. We checked the official tournament page, the host club site, and the registration portal, and found no stated hotel requirement or approved-hotel list. **Pending Confirmation** — we will confirm directly with the tournament director (Tripp Miller, tripp@scufc.com) and update this section. Our recommendation is to book a cancellable rate now rather than wait.

Where to stay

We look at two areas. **Harbison** (northwest Columbia, just off I-26) is the closest cluster to the venue with real availability. **Irmo** itself is closest of all, but was **80% booked out** for October 2–4 when we checked.

Closest to the venue

Hyatt Place Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$399 per night • \$798 for two nights
Drive: 5.9 mi • ~12 min to Ballentine Park

Hampton Inn Columbia I-26/Harbison Blvd — our pick

Rate: \$284 per night • \$568 for two nights
Room: King room with sofa bed, 2 beds total
Includes: Hot breakfast included, free cancellation, no prepayment
Drive: 7.0 mi • ~13 min to Ballentine Park

Country Inn & Suites by Radisson, Columbia at Harbison

Rate: \$161 per night • \$321 for two nights
Drive: 8.2 mi • ~15 min to Ballentine Park

Also available — slightly further out

Ramada Limited – Columbia	\$100/nt • 12.0 mi, ~21 min
TownePlace Suites by Marriott Columbia West/Lexington	\$299/nt • 13.7 mi, ~22 min
Residence Inn by Marriott Columbia West/Lexington	\$319/nt • 13.7 mi, ~21 min
Tru by Hilton Columbia Greystone	\$598/nt • 13.5 mi, ~21 min

The Hampton Inn, Residence Inn, and TownePlace Suites are Marriott properties — Bonvoy points eligible.

Important: Rates above were pulled live on September 13, 2026 for two nights (October 2–4), two adults and one child, and are subject to change. Driving distances were verified independently by routing against the actual venue address at 1009 Bickley Road — not copied from a tournament portal. We recommend booking a free-cancellation rate now and re-checking before you travel.

7. Weather & Heat Planning

We are nearly three weeks out, so a daily forecast is not yet meaningful. What follows is what early October has actually looked like in Columbia over the past ten years, so families can plan clothing and hydration sensibly.

Typical early-October conditions in Columbia

Afternoon high	Around 80°F on average — has reached 95°F
Morning low	Around 63°F — noticeably cool at the first game

Rain	Roughly a 1-in-6 chance of measurable rain on any given day
Sun	Strong — open complexes with limited shade
Best games	Morning games are meaningfully cooler than afternoon

What this means for packing

This is a two-wardrobe weekend. Bring the heat gear — water, electrolytes, sunscreen, cooling towels — but also bring a jacket or warm layer for early mornings and a rain shell, because October in the Midlands is not August. Start hydrating the day before travel.

Based on ten years of recorded daily observations for Columbia, SC. **Check the actual forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions. Source data: Open-Meteo historical archive (2016–2025).

8. Venue, Parking & Fields

Official Tournament Information: The Carolina Cup is played across five SCUFC complexes in the Columbia and Irmo area. Our team's specific complex and field will be assigned when the schedule is posted on September 24. Below are all five, so you can see where you might be going.

Ballentine Park Complex

1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Listed as the tournament's primary venue on the event listing.

SCUFC West Soccer Complex

1053 Bird Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Polo Road Park

730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29229

Southeastern Freight Lines Soccer Center

115 Sunbelt Blvd, Columbia, SC 29203

SV Presbyterian Church Fields

125 Sparkleberry Lane, Columbia, SC 29229

Parking

Cost	Free — SCUFC complexes have on-site parking
Fill time	Fills early on tournament mornings
Fields	Grass; specific field layouts published per complex by SCUFC
Amenities	Concessions and restrooms at the complexes

Official field layouts (published by SCUFC):[Ballentine Park field layout](#)[SCUFC West field layout](#)[Polo Road Park field layout](#)[Southeastern Freight Lines field layout](#)

Parent Manager Recommendation: Arrive 30–45 minutes before your first game to secure parking and walk to your field. These are large, spread-out complexes.

9. Team Communication Plan

Official schedule	SincSports (Carolina Cup)
Team updates	PlayMetrics Messages • Email
Tournament logistics	Parent Manager
Soccer questions	Coach
Urgent changes	Team chat / text

An updated guide will be sent as soon as the schedule is released.

10. Coach Updates (Coming Soon)

This section will be updated once our coaches release arrival times, uniform details, and any team-specific instructions.

Parents do not need to act on these items — they are for reference once confirmed by the coaching staff.

11. Player Guidance

Tournament weekends are exciting and demanding for young players. A few practical reminders.

- Prioritize sleep — early bedtimes Friday and Saturday
- Keep meals familiar — not the weekend for new foods
- Bring simple, preferred snacks
- Encourage steady hydration through the day
- Limit exhausting hotel-pool activity before games
- Bring quiet activities for downtime between games
- Expect physical and emotional fatigue
- Keep postgame conversations positive and brief
- Let coaches handle the soccer instruction
- Emphasize effort, teamwork, learning, and fun

12. Packing Checklist

Player Gear

- ☐ Both uniform kits
- ☐ Cleats
- ☐ Shin guards
- ☐ Labeled water bottle
- ☐ Extra socks
- ☐ Warm-up / training gear
- ☐ Dry clothes
- ☐ Recovery shoes or sandals
- ☐ Personal medications
- ☐ Warm layer for early games

Weather & Hydration

- ☐ Water (plenty)
- ☐ Electrolytes
- ☐ Sunscreen (SPF 50+)
- ☐ Cooling towel
- ☐ Rain gear / shell
- ☐ Small fan
- ☐ Plastic bags for wet gear
- ☐ Extra blanket or jacket

Parent Sideline

- ☐ Folding chairs
- ☐ Umbrella
- ☐ Cooler
- ☐ Snacks
- ☐ Portable charger
- ☐ Wipes
- ☐ Trash bags
- ☐ Activities for siblings
- ☐ Cash for concessions
- ☐ Shade if permitted

Emergency

- ☐ Basic first-aid supplies
- ☐ Ice packs
- ☐ Insurance information
- ☐ Emergency contacts
- ☐ Prescriptions

13. Tournament Rules

Pending Confirmation

SCUFC has not published the 2026 Carolina Cup rules document. Game length, mercy rule, substitution rules, and the tiebreaker order are all still unconfirmed for this year. **We will not guess at these.** As soon as the rules are published we'll add the full breakdown — including the complete tiebreaker hierarchy — to this section and resend the guide.

What we do know

Format	7v7 for U8–U10 age groups
Age groups	U8–U19, boys and girls
Levels	Recreational, Intermediate, Advanced
Sanctioning	US Youth Soccer affiliated (SC Youth Soccer)
Check-in	Online only — no on-site check-in

Rules questions: Tournament Director Tripp Miller — tripp@scufc.com

Bracket questions (U8–U12): Jamie McClendon — jamie@scufc.com

14. Nearby Family Resources

Distances measured from Ballentine Park Complex, 1009 Bickley Road. Information current as of September 13, 2026.

Closest to the venue

CVS Pharmacy	0.3 mi
Food Lion	0.4 mi
Walmart Supercenter	1.1 mi • 1180 Dutch Fork Road
Publix	2.3 mi • 2732 North Lake Drive

Forgot something?

Dick's Sporting Goods	6.2 mi • 1110 Bower Parkway
Academy Sports + Outdoors	6.2 mi

Near the Harbison hotel cluster

Trader Joe's	275 Harbison Boulevard
Publix	150 Harbison Boulevard
Rite Aid	5.1 mi from the venue

15. Weekend Itinerary

Friday, October 2

Travel day for most families. Leave Savannah by early afternoon to avoid the worst of the Friday build-up — the drive is about 3h 15min in free-flow conditions and closer to 4 hours with traffic and a stop. Check in, get dinner, early bedtime for players.

Saturday, October 3 — Group Play

Pending Confirmation. Schedule releases September 24. Expect multiple group games. Player report time is 45 minutes before each kickoff. Once we have times we'll send calculated departure times for each family.

Sunday, October 4 — Knockout Rounds

Pending Confirmation. Depends on Saturday's results. Note that Sunday may not run late — plan your checkout and departure around whether your team advances, and give yourself time for the drive home.

16. Quick Reference

Screenshot this for game day.

Tournament	26th Annual Carolina Cup
Team	Savannah United 17/18B
Dates	Oct 2–4, 2026
Venue	Ballentine Park Complex, Irmo SC
Address	1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063
Drive	~169 mi • ~3h 15min
Hotel	Hampton Inn Harbison • \$284/nt • 7.0 mi
Format	U9 • 7v7
Check-in	Online only — opens after Sep 14
Weather	~63°F morning / ~80°F afternoon • layers + heat gear
Director	Tripp Miller • tripp@scufc.com
SCUFC	877-457-2832

17. Final Next Steps

1. **Book your hotel now.** The Irmo area was 80% booked when we checked. A free-cancellation rate costs nothing to hold.

2. **Watch for the accepted team list on September 14**, then complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in at this tournament.
3. **Check the bracket September 16** and the **schedule September 24**. We'll send a refreshed guide with departure times once game times are live.
4. **Pack for two climates** — cool mornings, warm afternoons, and a real chance of rain.
5. **Check the forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions.

Go, Savannah United!

Looking forward to a great weekend in Columbia. Safe travels, and we'll send the updated guide as soon as the schedule drops.